

peanut ball to support labour



Peanut balls are a versatile tool to help open the pelvis, encourage your baby to rotate, and support labour progress, this tool is especially helpful if you have an epidural or need to rest in bed.

Side-Lying Peanut Ball

What it is:

A comfortable side lying position with a peanut ball between the knees, keeping hips stacked or slightly forward.

How to do it:

1. Lie on your side in bed.
2. Place the peanut ball between your thighs/knees.
3. Keep hips stacked or slightly forward.
4. Support your head and belly with pillows.

Benefits:

- Opens the pelvic inlet and mid pelvis
- Encourages baby descent and dilation
- Restful and safe with epidural

Ideal for:

- Early to active labour
- Labouring with epidural
- When energy is low but progress is needed

Baby positions helped:

- General descent
- Mild posterior or OT babies

Doula tips:

- Adjust ball size to avoid hip strain
- Tilt the top knee slightly forward to increase pelvic opening
- Swap sides every 30–60 minutes



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Kneeling & Leaning Forward (Supported Hands and Knees)

What it is:

A forward-leaning, kneeling position using the peanut ball for support.

How to do it:

1. Kneel on the bed or floor.
2. Place the peanut ball under your chest or arms.
3. Lean forward and let your belly relax.
4. Rock gently if comfortable.

Benefits:

- Encourages optimal fetal positioning
- Relieves back labour
- Improves sacral mobility
- Uses gravity without pressure on cervix

Ideal for:

- Active labour
- Back labour
- Posterior baby

Baby positions helped:

- Posterior (OP)
- OT (transverse)
- Asynclitic head position

Doula tips:

- Add gentle hip rocking or figure 8 movements
- Combine with rebozo or counter pressure if helpful



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Upright Straddle (Sitting Astride Peanut Ball)

What it is:

Sitting upright, astride the peanut ball, with feet wide and grounded.

How to do it:

1. Sit upright astride the peanut ball.
2. Keep feet wide and grounded.
3. Lean slightly forward or remain upright.
4. Support yourself with a partner or bed as needed.

Benefits:

- Opens the pelvic outlet
- Encourages descent and rotation
- Uses gravity to support labour
- Promotes active coping

Ideal for:

- Active labour
- Transition (if comfortable)
- When dilation slows

Baby positions helped:

- Descent issues
- OT or slightly posterior babies

Doula tips:

- Encourage pelvic circles or gentle tilts
- Keep knees lower than hips if possible
- Great for grounding between contractions



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Flying Cowgirl (Side-Lying Half-Wheel)

What it is:

A side lying, asymmetrical “half-wheel” position with knees wide, feet together, and a gentle spinal arch. Opens the top of the pelvis for baby rotation.

How to do it:

1. Lie on your side in bed.
2. Place a peanut ball between your legs with knees wide apart.
3. Bring the soles of your feet together (butterfly shape).
4. Gently arch your back into a half-wheel shape.
5. Relax your belly, hips, shoulders, and jaw.
6. Stay for 3–6 contractions, then switch sides and repeat.

Benefits:

- Opens the top of the pelvis for baby rotation and descent
- Encourages optimal fetal positioning
- Supports early labour progress
- Gentle and restful, ideal with epidural or early labour

Ideal for:

- Early labour at home
- Labouring in bed with epidural
- Posterior or high baby

Baby positions helped:

- Posterior (OP)
- OT (transverse)
- Asynclitic head position
- High or unengaged head

Doula tips:

- Slightly roll the top hip forward for more pelvic opening
- Combine with gentle hip squeezes or sacral pressure
- Encourage soft breathing and relaxation



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Upright Asymmetrical Sitting (One-Knee Peanut Ball)

What it is:

An upright, asymmetrical seated position where one knee is supported by a peanut ball. This creates uneven pelvic space, encouraging baby to rotate and descend while using gravity.

How to do it

1. Sit upright on the bed or chair
2. Place the peanut ball under one knee so that leg is lifted and supported.
3. Keep the other foot grounded on the floor or bed.
4. Sit tall or lean slightly forward for comfort.
5. Relax your shoulders, jaw, and pelvic floor.
6. Stay in the position for 3–6 contractions, then switch sides and repeat.

Tip: Use pillows or a partner for back support if needed.

Benefits

- Creates asymmetrical pelvic opening
- Encourages baby to rotate into an optimal position
- Supports descent and dilation
- Uses gravity while maintaining pelvic mobility
- Gentle but effective — ideal when labour feels slow or “stuck”
- Suitable for labouring in bed or with an epidural (with support)

Ideal For

- Active labour
- Slow progress or stalled dilation
- Babies needing help rotating
- Labouring upright with rest
- Epidural supported movement

Baby Positions Helped

- Posterior (OP)
- OT (transverse)
- Asynclitic head position

Doula Tips

- Think “upright lunge with support.”
- Slightly roll the lifted knee outward to increase pelvic opening.
- Encourage gentle rocking or small pelvic circles.



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Quick Doula Decision Guide:

If labour is slow:

- Flying cowgirl
- Upright straddle
- Side lying (with asymmetry)

If baby is posterior/back labour:

- Kneeling & leaning forward
- Flying cowgirl
- Side lying with top leg forward

if epidural is in place:

- Side lying
- Semi reclined with peanut ball
- Assisted flying cowgirl (with staff support)

If birthing person is exhausted:

- Side-lying
- Semi-reclined peanut ball
- Micro-movements instead of big changes

! Safety & Comfort Notes

- Always prioritise comfort and consent.
- Avoid if pain in hips, knees, or pubic bone.
- Adjust ball size and support with pillows/inflation
- Work with midwife/obstetric guidance if epidural or monitoring is in place.
- Positions are suggestions, not prescriptions.

Every labour is different, and there is no “right” way to use a peanut ball.

These positions are options, not rules. If something feels uncomfortable or unhelpful, trust your body and change it.

Try a position for a few contractions, notice how your body and baby respond, and follow what feels supportive. Even small adjustments can make a big difference.

- Your body knows what to do.
- Movement is a guide, not a demand.
- Comfort and intuition matter.

If you feel unsure or concerned about progress at any point, reach out to your midwife or birth team for support.

If you'd like personalised guidance on using movement, positioning, and comfort measures in labour, birth-hood offers:

- 1:1 doula support
- birth preparation sessions

